

BOB INGRAM



McFarlin

McFarlin has eyes on his 1980 Miners

BACK IN THOSE cold early days of February, there were great expectations that the U.T. El Paso baseballers were headed for a winning season. They had just taken three out of four games from the Oklahoma Sooners of the Big Eight.

It hasn't turned out that way and even if the Miners should sweep the New Mexico Lobos tomorrow and Saturday in Albuquerque, they would still have a deficit for the year.

The Miners are 1-11 in WAC play and 20-25 in overall competition.

Larry McFarlin, the rookie coach of the Miners, comes to the boiling point in a hurry. He admits to being tossed out of two games during the season, and, if you believe eyewitnesses, he was chased in still another one. It was played against New Mexico Aggies and was forfeited to them when McFarlin engaged in a heated argument with the umpire. McFarlin claims he was not chased in this game although his whole team had to take a walk.

Despite his temper, McFarlin seldom if ever got angry at his players. "They worked hard all season," he said. "We knew our shortcomings. There was a certain lack of depth in the pitching. We had three good starters. There wasn't much help from the bullpen. We scored enough runs to win several games. Hitting fell off in the latter part of the season. Fielding remained about the same throughout the season."

NICK FIORILLO, the leader of the pitching staff with a 6-4 record, is expected to get a tryout with the Cincinnati Reds. He's a lefty with a good deal of potential. Tom Cartier, another pitcher, third baseman Mike Brooks and outfielder Dom Fleagler are other Miners who may go in the draft.

When McFarlin played for the Miners in the 1960s and set several

hitting records, the school gave out only five baseball scholarships.

The number has now been increased to 13, which is the NCAA limit.

That's going to help McFarlin in the future. He's already been on recruiting trips and he'll be back out combing the territory next week.

He has no fault to find with the material left him by the venerated Andy Cohen, but he's anxious to build his own team.

Besides getting a full scholarship load, he will get more coaching help next season. Athletic director Jim Bowden has granted his wish for two or three student assistant coaches.

ONE DISADVANTAGE though will be the loss of the campus field. Expansion plans of the university call for a new building to be constructed where the Miners' diamond now stands.

McFarlin hopes to relocate in an area close to the campus. He has a site picked out near the Rudolph Chevrolet Co. plant. It will be more accessible than Dudley Field and will have most of the aspects of a campus resort.

McFarlin's big job is going to be building up Miner baseball where it will be both competitive and entertaining enough to draw crowds. That will take some time.

The Miners, as most college teams do, use aluminum bats. What the fans who saw them play heard was the ping of the bat against the ball instead of the crack of the ball against a wooden bat, although some of the hickory and ash bats were used.

The aluminum bats were tougher than the wood bats. "We seldom ever broke an aluminum bat," said McFarlin. "However, some of them were bent a little."

Maybe that's what happened to the Miners this season. They bent but did not break.